Current Affairs 31-10-2026

Credit - Drishti Ias

Youth Unrest under Neoliberalism

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For Prelims: G7 nations , Neoliberal capitalism , Article 41 , Gig economy , Right to Life , Demographic Dividend

For Mains: Globalisation, social empowerment, demographic changes and social inequalities.

Source:TH

Why in News?

Across the globe from **G7 nations** like France and Spain to countries in the Global South like India, Sri Lanka, and Bangladesh a massive wave of **youth-led protests** is unfolding. These mobilizations are a collective reaction to the systemic failures of **neoliberal capitalism** , which has weakened public welfare, skyrocketed the cost of living, and worsened youth unemployment.

Summary

- Youth unrest under neoliberalism reflects growing unemployment, insecure gig work, rising living costs, wealth concentration and intergenerational inequality, threatening social cohesion and democratic stability.
- Addressing these challenges requires stronger welfare systems, labour protections, progressive wealth redistribution, future-oriented skill development and green jobs to ensure inclusive growth and intergenerational justice.

What is Neoliberalism?

- **About:** Neoliberalism is a political and economic ideology that gained global dominance in the late 20th century (post-1970s) as a counter-revolution to the **state-led "Golden Age of Capitalism" (1945-1973).**
  - It fundamentally advocates for free-market capitalism, minimal government intervention, and comprehensive economic liberalization.

- **Key Pillars:**
  - **Free-Market Capitalism:** The belief that **markets operate most efficiently without government intervention.**
  - **Withdrawal of the Welfare State:** Aggressive reduction in public expenditure, subsidies, and social safety nets.
  - **Deregulation & Privatization:** Removing state controls over the financial sector and transferring public utilities to private corporations.
  - **Labor Market "Flexibility":** Dismantling labor unions and workers' protections to **lower wage costs,** effectively using the threat of **unemployment (the 'sack')** as a disciplinary measure against the working class.

What are the Youth Concerns Regarding Neoliberalism?

- **Crisis of Unemployment and Underconsumption:** As neoliberalism suppressed **wages to maximize corporate profits** , the **purchasing power** of the working class declined.
  - According to **heterodox economists** (like Karl Marx's theory of underconsumption), when workers cannot afford goods, capitalists stop investing, leading to a massive lack of labor demand.
  - Consequently, youth unemployment rates in G7 countries are now almost twice as high as overall unemployment.
  - According to the **India Employment Report 2024** , youth account for nearly 83% of the unemployed workforce in India.
  - This systemic failure contradicts the **Directive Principle (Article 41)** , which mandates the State to secure the Right to Work and public assistance in cases of unemployment.
- **Commodification of Education:** Under neoliberalism, higher education transitioned from a **public good to a profit-driven industry.**
  - The youth face skyrocketing tuition fees and **massive student debt,** only to graduate into a market experiencing **"credential inflation" with few remunerative jobs.**
- **Casualization of Labor and Dilution of Rights:** Neoliberalism prioritized "labor market flexibility," replacing secure, pensionable, and **unionized jobs with contract work, zero-hour contracts, and gig economy roles .**
  - This has stripped the **youth of job security, medical benefits, and collective bargaining rights.**
  - This increasing precarity raises serious questions about the state's obligation to protect the **Right to Livelihood** , which the Supreme Court explicitly read as a fundamental part of the **Right to Life (Article 21)** in *Olga Tellis vs. Bombay Municipal Corporation (1985)* .
  - While the **Code on Social Security, 2020** explicitly recognizes "gig workers" and "platform workers", it falls short of granting them traditional "employee" status, thereby **denying them minimum wage guarantees and collective bargaining rights.**
- **Feminization of Precarity:** Young women face a double burden disproportionately pushed into unpaid care work as state welfare shrinks, or relegated to the lowest, most insecure tiers of the gig economy.
- **The AI and Automation:** The youth face general economic stagnation compounded by capital-intensive growth.
  - **Artificial Intelligence (AI) is eroding entry-level white-collar jobs** - the traditional first rung of the social mobility ladder for educated youth.

- **Intergenerational Environmental Injustice:** The neoliberal pursuit of endless, **resource-intensive growth** has externalized environmental costs.
  - Older generations contributed the **most to global warming,** but the catastrophic economic and ecological consequences of the **climate crisis** are being entirely inherited by the youth.
  - A 2021 study based on **IPCC** data reveals a child born in 2020 will face **7x more heatwaves and 2.8x more floods** than someone born in 1960.
  - A **World Bank report** warns that India could account for **34 million of the projected 80 million global job losses** from heat stress-related productivity declines by 2030, an economic burden falling directly on the incoming youth workforce.
- **Asset Price Inflation:** Prolonged **pro-capital policies have inflated** the costs of assets like real estate. The youth are priced out of homeownership and trapped in an economy of "rentier capitalism."
  - This massive concentration of wealth directly violates **Article 38(2)** (striving to minimize income inequalities) and **Article 39(b) & (c)** (mandating that material resources subserve the common good and the economic system does not result in the concentration of wealth).
- **Dismantling of Social Safety Nets:** There has been a systemic transfer of economic risk from the state and corporations onto the individual.
  - For instance, the shift from state-backed pensions to market-linked retirement funds forces the youth to navigate volatile financial markets for their future security.
- **Political Alienation:** Perceived corruption, nepotism, unequal opportunities and weak political responsiveness erode youth trust in democratic **institutions and meritocracy, fuelling protests across Albania and Europe.**

How Current Youth Unrest against Neoliberalism Differs from Historical Movements?

- **Economic Protection vs. Cultural Freedom:** In 1968, youth operating within a robust welfare state protested for **greater social and cultural freedom.** Today, facing neoliberal state withdrawal, youth demand basic economic protection.
- **The 'Precariat' vs. The Proletariat:** Historical movements relied on strong, unionized industrial workers. Today's unrest is driven by the precariat (a scattered, highly indebted class of gig workers and desperate graduates).
  - The massive **2022 RRB-NTPC railway protests** in UP and Bihar perfectly illustrate this, highlighting the **extreme desperation of millions of educated youth for a shrinking pool of secure formal jobs.**
- **Leaderless Networks vs. Vanguard Leadership:** Past protests were steered by charismatic leaders (like Jayaprakash Narayan in India) and vanguard unions with clear ideological frameworks.
  - Today’s digital-age mobilizations are decentralized, leaderless, and organized via social media, making them resilient to state crackdowns but often ideologically fragmented.
- **"Polycrisis" vs. Utopian Optimism:** 1960s/70s youth possessed revolutionary optimism to build a utopian society (e.g., the demand for "Total Revolution").
  - Today’s Gen Z is driven by **eco-anxiety and a "polycrisis" mindset** (enduring systemic shocks from the **2008 crash** , **Covid-19** , and **climate change**), protesting out of a **desperate need to survive a bleak, insecure future.**

What are the Implications of Rising Youth Unrest?

- **Economic Disruption and Investment Uncertainty** : Prolonged social unrest can disrupt economic activity, undermine business confidence and discourage investment.
  - According to IMF research (2021), major unrest events were associated, on average, with GDP being approximately 1% below baseline six quarters after the event.
- **Political Polarisation and Democratic Instability:** Persistent economic grievances may intensify political polarisation and create opportunities for extremist or populist political mobilisation.
  - France's 2026 protests illustrate how socioeconomic discontent can become intertwined with electoral competition and law-and-order politics.
- **Erosion of Institutional Trust:** Unaddressed youth grievances, perceived corruption and inadequate public services can weaken confidence in representative institutions, undermining democratic legitimacy and social cohesion.
- **Potential for Democratic Renewal:** Peaceful youth mobilisation can also promote accountability, institutional reforms and greater political participation by bringing neglected issues into public debate.

Click here to Read: Gen Z Protests: Redefining Democratic Participation in India

What Measures are Needed to Address Intergenerational Inequality under Neoliberalism?

- **Re-calibrating the Labor Market for the 'Precariat':** State intervention is crucial to protect vulnerable workers in the new digital and gig economy.
  - The government must enforce the **2020 recommendations of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Labour** to clearly define employer-employee relationships.
  - The Code on Social Security must be amended to guarantee minimum living wages, algorithmic transparency, and mandatory health insurance for all gig and platform workers.
- **Pivoting to Universal Basic Services (UBS):** The State must prioritize **Universal Basic Services** (ensuring high-quality public healthcare, education, and affordable social housing) to de-commodify fundamental human needs.
  - Existing targeted schemes like **Ayushman Bharat (PM-JAY)** for healthcare and **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY)** for housing must be progressively expanded toward universal entitlements, ensuring the youth are not trapped in rent-heavy, debt-ridden living.
- **Progressive Wealth Redistribution:** Adopting the **World Inequality Lab's** recommendations on **progressive taxation** (such as taxing extreme wealth, corporate monopolies, and inheritances) will generate the fiscal space needed to fund youth welfare, student debt relief, and the green energy transition.
- **Aligning Education with the Future of Work:** To combat "credential inflation," the education system must transition from traditional degree-centric models to agile skilling ecosystems.
  - The **National Education Policy (NEP) 2020** must aggressively integrate vocational training.
  - Initiatives like **FutureSkills Prime** and **PM Kaushal Vikas Yojana (PMKVY 4.0)** must be scaled up to upskill youth in Industry 4.0 technologies (Artificial Intelligence, IoT, 3D printing, and drones) to bridge the real-world employability gap.
- **Ensuring a 'Just Transition' for Climate Action:** Economic planning must centre on a **'Just Transition' framework** .
  - The **Skill Council for Green Jobs (SCGJ)** should be heavily funded to align workforce training with the employment demands of the **National Green Hydrogen Mission** and the **International Solar**

Alliance (ISA) .

- Massive state investments in climate adaptation and renewable energy infrastructure will **create millions of sustainable "green jobs,"** effectively turning the climate crisis into an employment opportunity for the youth.

- **Intergenerationally Equitable Fiscal Policy:** Governments must balance spending on the elderly (pensions and social security) with investments in the youth (education, housing, and jobs) to ensure an aging demographic doesn't drain resources and opportunities from future generations.

Conclusion

Global youth unrest reflects the structural inequalities of neoliberal capitalism. Addressing it requires a shift towards inclusive growth, equitable wealth distribution, secure employment and intergenerational justice, with the State playing a stronger role in ensuring social and economic equity.

Drishti Mains Question:

Rising youth unrest across the world reflects deeper structural inequalities associated with neoliberal capitalism. Examine its causes and implications for democratic stability.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is Neoliberalism?
Neoliberalism is an economic and political ideology advocating free-market capitalism, deregulation, privatization and reduced government intervention in the economy.

2. What is meant by the Precariat?
The precariat refers to a class of workers facing insecure employment, irregular incomes and limited social protection, particularly in the gig and informal economies.

3. Which constitutional provisions support economic and social justice?
Articles 38 and 39 promote distributive justice and prevent wealth concentration, while Article 41 directs the State to secure the right to work and public assistance.

4. How does the Code on Social Security, 2020 address gig workers?
It formally recognizes gig workers and platform workers and provides a framework for social security measures, but does not grant them conventional employee status.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/JvOG0LKLGYs]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. Capitalism has guided the world economy to unprecedented prosperity. However, it often encourages short-sightedness and contributes to wide disparities between the rich and the poor. In this light, would it be correct to believe and adopt capitalism for bringing inclusive growth in India? Discuss. **(2014)**

Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme (CMPS)

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

The Union Cabinet approved the **Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme (CMPS) to boost domestic shipping-container manufacturing** , reduce import dependence and strengthen India's maritime supply-chain resilience.

What are the Key Facts About the Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme?

- **About:** CMPS is a Central Government initiative announced in the **Union Budget 2026–27** to establish a globally competitive container manufacturing ecosystem in India.
- **Nodal Ministry:** Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (MoPSW).
- **Financial Outlay: ₹10,000 crore, with the scheme covering 2027–28 to 2039–40** , including three years for establishing manufacturing facilities and ten years of production support.
- **Objectives:** Promote domestic container manufacturing, import substitution, supply-chain resilience, export competitiveness and employment generation.
- **Coverage:** Supports both **greenfield projects (new manufacturing facilities)** and **brownfield projects (expansion of existing facilities).**
- **Capacity Target:** Increase India's annual container manufacturing capacity from approximately **70,000 TEUs to 7.5 lakh TEUs** , representing nearly a tenfold expansion.
- **Strategic Alignment:** Complements **Make in India , Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047 , PM GatiShakti and the National Logistics Policy .**

What are Shipping Containers?

- Shipping containers are **standardised steel freight boxes** used to transport goods across ships, railways and road vehicles without unloading and repacking cargo during transfers.
- Manufactured according to **International Organization for Standardization (ISO) standards** , they enable efficient intermodal transport and global trade.
- The most common sizes are **20-foot and 40-foot containers** , with capacity measured in **Twenty-foot Equivalent Units (TEUs)** .



What are the Major Components of the Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme?

- **Interest Subvention Assistance (ISA):** Provides **3% annual interest subvention on eligible term loans** , with an allocation of **₹859 crore** , to support new container manufacturing facilities and expansion of existing units.
  - Greenfield projects must have an annual capacity of at least **1,00,000 TEUs** , while brownfield projects must add at least **25,000 TEUs** of annual capacity.
  - Eligible facilities must be **commissioned within three years of in-principle approval** and comply with international container manufacturing standards.
- **Operational Expenditure Assistance (OEA):** Provides **₹8,891 crore** in financial assistance for internationally compliant containers manufactured and sold by eligible producers, aimed at bridging the cost gap with imported containers.
  - Requires **70% minimum local content through FY 2031–32** , increasing to **90% from FY 2032–33** .
- **Testing and Certification Assistance:** Allocates **₹150 crore** for common testing and certification facilities to ensure compliance with international container manufacturing and safety standards.
  - Includes **dynamic longitudinal impact testing** to assess containers' structural resistance to transportation and handling impacts.
- **Scheme Management:** ₹100 crore for scheme administration, monitoring and implementation support.

What are the Expected Outcomes of the Container

Manufacturing Promotion Scheme?

- **Expansion of Domestic Manufacturing:** CMPS aims to significantly expand indigenous container production, strengthening India's maritime manufacturing ecosystem and industrial capabilities.
- **Import Substitution and Supply-Chain Resilience:** Greater domestic container availability can **reduce dependence on foreign suppliers, particularly China,** and minimise vulnerability to global container shortages and supply disruptions.
- **Global Export Competitiveness:** Internationally compliant and cost-competitive manufacturing could position India as a container export hub, strengthening its participation in global maritime value chains.
- **Employment Generation:** The scheme is expected to generate approximately **3,000 direct jobs and over 50,000 indirect jobs** across manufacturing, logistics and allied sectors.
- **Ancillary Industry Development:** Increased production can **stimulate domestic industries supplying specialised steel,** corner castings, flooring materials, coatings and other container components.
- **Private Investment and Technology Adoption:** Financial incentives can **encourage investment in modern manufacturing facilities** , advanced production technologies and internationally compliant testing infrastructure.
- **Multimodal Logistics Support:** Improved domestic container availability can **facilitate cargo movement across ports, railways and roads,** although actual logistics efficiency and freight costs will also depend on transport connectivity, port performance and container distribution.



What are the Other Initiatives Strengthening India's Maritime Ecosystem?

Bharat Container Shipping Line (BCSL)

- **About:** An **MoU was signed in February 2026** to establish the **Bharat Container Shipping Line** and strengthen India's domestically anchored container shipping ecosystem.
- **Participating Institutions** : The initiative brings together **Shipping Corporation of India (SCI), Container Corporation of India (CONCOR), Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA), V.O. Chidambaranar Port Authority, Chennai Port Authority and Sagarmala Finance Corporation Limited** .
- **Objectives:** Improve container shipping connectivity, end-to-end logistics, freight cost stability and

trade competitiveness through coordination among shipping companies, ports and logistics institutions.

Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047

- **About:** Provides a long-term framework for transforming India's maritime sector through port modernisation, logistics efficiency, shipbuilding, sustainability and global competitiveness.
- **Container Traffic Projections:** India's container traffic is projected to increase from approximately 24 million TEUs in 2024 to 175 million TEUs by 2047, according to the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways.

Other Supporting Measures

Area of Support	Key Measures and Initiatives
Legislative Support	**Merchant Shipping Act, 2025** , **Coastal Shipping Act, 2025** and **Indian Ports Act, 2025**
Digital Support for Ease of Doing Business	**One Nation One Port Process (ONOP)** , **Maritime Single Window** and **e-Samudra**
Integrated Logistics Network	**PM Gati Shakti** , **National Logistics Policy (NLP)** and **Sagarmala Programme**

Conclusion

The Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme represents an important step towards developing a self-reliant, globally competitive maritime manufacturing ecosystem. By promoting domestic production, reducing import dependence and strengthening ancillary industries, **CMPS can enhance supply-chain resilience, logistics efficiency** and export competitiveness, supporting India's long-term maritime ambitions under **Viksit Bharat 2047** .

Drishti Mains Practice Question

India's growing dependence on containerised maritime trade highlights the importance of developing domestic manufacturing capabilities. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q1. What is the Container Manufacturing Promotion Scheme (CMPS)?
CMPS is a ₹10,000-crore Central Government scheme approved in October 2026 to promote domestic shipping-container manufacturing, reduce import dependence and strengthen maritime supply chains.

Q2. What is the target manufacturing capacity under CMPS?
The scheme aims to expand India's annual container manufacturing capacity to 7.5 lakh TEUs, approximately ten times the existing capacity.

Q3. What are the three major components of CMPS?
The scheme comprises Interest Subvention Assistance (₹859 crore), Operational Expenditure Assistance (₹8,891 crore) and Testing and Certification Assistance (₹150 crore).

Q4. What is the local-content requirement under CMPS?
Eligible manufacturers must maintain at least 70% local content through 2031–32, increasing to 90% from 2032–33.

Q5. What is a Twenty-foot Equivalent Unit (TEU)?
A TEU is a standard unit for measuring container capacity, equivalent to one 20-foot shipping container. A standard 40-foot container generally represents 2 TEUs.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/aKQR_et1KjA]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Question (PYQ)

Prelims

Q. What is the importance of developing Chabahar Port by India? (2017)

(a) India’s trade with African countries will enormously increase.

(b) India’s relations with oil-producing Arab countries will be strengthened.

(c) India will not depend on Pakistan for access to Afghanistan and Central Asia.

(d) Pakistan will facilitate and protect the installation of a gas pipeline between Iraq and India.

Ans: (c)

Mains

Q. “Investment in infrastructure is essential for more rapid and inclusive economic growth.” Discuss in the light of India’s experience. **(2021)**

Q. One of the intended objectives of Union-Budget 2017-18 is to ‘transform, energize and clean India’. Analyze the measures proposed in the Budget 2017-18 to achieve the objective. **(2017)**

Legislative Council (Vidhan Parishad): Role and Relevance

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Source: IE

Why in News?

Member of Legislative Council (MLC) elections in various states have brought the focus back onto the bicameral legislature system in Indian states, raising discussions on why only a few states possess a **Legislative Council (Vidhan Parishad) and what exact purpose they serve in the democratic framework.**

What is a Legislative Council?

- **About:** India follows a bicameral system at the Centre, comprising the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha.
  - The **Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms, 1919** introduced bicameralism at the Centre, while the **Government of India Act, 1935** provided for bicameral legislatures in certain provinces.
    - The Legislative Council first started functioning in the province of Bengal in 1937.
  - The Constitution allows states to adopt either a unicameral or bicameral legislature, comprising one or two Houses, respectively.
  - In states that opt for a bicameral setup, the legislature consists of two houses:
    - **Lower House (Vidhan Sabha / Legislative Assembly):** It is the popular house, directly elected by the people through universal adult suffrage.
    - **Upper House (Vidhan Parishad / Legislative Council):** It is the revising chamber of the state legislature. It is a permanent body and is not subject to dissolution.
- **Tenure:** Like the Rajya Sabha, the Legislative Council is a permanent House that cannot be dissolved. Its members **serve six-year terms, with one-third retiring every two years.**
- **Eligibility:** To contest for a seat as a Member of the Legislative Council (MLC), a **candidate must be at least 30 years old, compared to the 25-year age minimum required for the Legislative Assembly.**
- **Bicameral States:** Currently, **only six states** have a Legislative Council **: Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra, and Karnataka.**
  - ***(Note: Jammu and Kashmir had a council until the J&K Reorganisation Act, 2019).***
- **Constitutional Provisions:**
  - **Article 168 (Constitution of Legislatures in States):** Defines the structure of state legislatures, establishing whether a state operates with a unicameral system (only a Legislative Assembly) or a bicameral system (both an Assembly and a Legislative Council).
  - **Article 169 (Creation and Abolition):** The Parliament can abolish a Legislative Council (where it already exists) or create it (where it does not exist) by a **simple majority** , if the Legislative Assembly of the concerned state passes a resolution requesting it.
    - The state assembly's resolution must be passed by a **special majority** (i.e., a majority of the total

membership of the assembly and a majority of not less than two-thirds of the members of the assembly present and voting).

- **Article 171 (Composition):** The maximum strength of the council is fixed at **one-third of the total strength of the assembly** and the minimum strength is fixed at **40** . (This means the size of the council depends on the size of the assembly).

- **MLC Elections:** Unlike MLAs, MLCs are chosen through indirect elections using a system of proportional representation by means of a **single transferable vote.** The composition is as follows:
  - **1/3rd** are **elected by local bodies** like municipalities, Gram Panchayats, Panchayat Samitis, and Zila Parishads.
  - **1/3rd** are elected by the **members of the Legislative Assembly (MLAs)** of the State from amongst persons who are not members of the Assembly.
  - **1/12th** are elected by persons who are **graduates of three years' standing** residing in that state.
  - **1/12th** are **elected by teachers** who have spent at least three years teaching in educational institutions within the state not lower in standard than secondary schools.
  - **1/6th** are **nominated by the Governor** from persons having special knowledge or practical experience in fields such as literature, science, art, the cooperative movement, and social service.

Utility of the Legislative Councils

- **Check on Hasty Legislation:** It acts as a revising chamber that scrutinizes legislation passed in haste or **driven by populism by the Legislative Assembly.**
- **Representation of Diverse Interests:** It provides a platform for teachers, graduates, and local bodies to have a direct say in the legislative process.
- **Accommodating Experts:** The nomination quota allows for the **inclusion of eminent personalities, subject matter experts,** and non-political individuals who might shy away from the rough and tumble of direct electoral politics.
- **Sharing the Burden:** By initiating **non-financial bills** , the Council can share the heavy legislative workload of the Assembly.

Why Do Only Some Indian States Have Legislative Councils?

- **Financial Burden:** Maintaining a secondary house **requires substantial expenditure on salaries, allowances,** and infrastructure, which is a significant drain on the state exchequer, especially for smaller states.
- **"Parking Lot" for Politicians:** The Legislative Council is often criticized for being **used to accommodate political leaders** who have lost democratic elections or to satisfy coalition partners, rather than accommodating intellectuals and experts.
- **Limited Legislative Powers:** Unlike the **Rajya Sabha** , the Vidhan Parishad has very limited powers.
  - Under Article 197 of the Constitution, the Legislative Council cannot **veto a Bill passed by the Legislative Assembly** and can only delay an ordinary Bill for a maximum of four months (three months initially and one month on reconsideration).
  - The Legislative Council cannot introduce or reject **Money Bills,** but may recommend amendments within 14 days. The Legislative Assembly may accept or reject these recommendations.
  - Unlike Parliament, state bicameral legislatures have no provision for a joint sitting to resolve legislative

deadlocks.

- **Delaying Mechanism:** Critics argue that it merely acts as a dilatory chamber that delays the passage of crucial legislation without adding substantial value.
- **Lack of Federal Imperative:** The Rajya Sabha represents the states at the Union level, which is crucial for a federal structure. The Legislative Council does not serve a similar federal purpose at the state level; it **merely represents different functional classes and local bodies.**

Rajya Sabha and State Legislative Council

Feature	Rajya Sabha (Council of States)	State Legislative Council (Vidhan Parishad)
Constitutional Provision	**Article 80** deals with its composition.	**Article 169** (Creation/Abolition) and **Article 171** (Composition).
Status of Existence	It is a permanent constitutional body and **cannot be abolished** .	It can be **created or abolished** by the Parliament if the State Legislative Assembly passes a resolution requesting it.
Maximum & Minimum Strength	Maximum strength is **250** members. No constitutional minimum.	Maximum strength is **1/3rd** of the State Legislative Assembly; Minimum is **40** members.
Nominated Members	**12 members** are nominated by the President.	**1/6th of total members** are nominated by the Governor.
Presiding Officer	The **Vice-President of India** serves as the ex-officio Chairman.	The **Chairman is elected** by the Council members from amongst themselves.
Legislative Deadlock	A **Joint Sitting** (Article 108) can be summoned by the President to resolve disagreements with the Lok Sabha.	**No provision for a joint sitting** .
Electoral Participation	Elected members vote in the election of the **President** , and all members vote for the **Vice-President** .	Members **do not participate** in the election of the President or the Vice-President.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. Which constitutional provisions govern State Legislative Councils?
Article 169 deals with their creation and abolition, while Article 171 specifies their composition and strength.

2. What is the procedure for creating or abolishing a Legislative Council?
The State Legislative Assembly must pass a resolution by a special majority. Parliament can then enact a law by a simple majority, as the law is not treated as a constitutional amendment under Article 368.

3. How are Members of Legislative Councils elected or nominated?
One-third are elected by local authorities, one-third by MLAs, one-twelfth by graduates, one-twelfth by teachers, and the remaining one-sixth are nominated by the Governor.

4. What are the main limitations of a Legislative Council?
It cannot permanently veto ordinary bills, can delay them for a maximum of four months, and has no power to reject or amend a Money Bill.

5. Which Indian states currently have Legislative Councils?
The six states are Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Maharashtra and Karnataka. Jammu and Kashmir's Legislative Council was abolished following the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act, 2019.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/pY5rMiEgZ8c]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions

Prelims

Q. Consider the following statements in respect of questions asked by the Members in the Parliament of India: (2026)

1. Unstarred questions are those to which a Member desires an oral answer in the House.
2. Starred questions are those to which a Member desires a written answer.
3. No supplementary question can be asked on an unstarred question.

Which one of the following conclusions based on the above statements is correct?

a) All the three statements are correct.

b) There are two correct statements, that include statement 2.

c) There is only one correct statement.

d) There is no correct statement.

Ans: C

Q. With reference to the Indian Parliament consider the following statements: (2024)

1. A bill pending in the Lok Sabha lapses on its dissolution.
2. A bill passed by the Lok Sabha and pending in the Rajya Sabha lapses on the dissolution of the Lok Sabha.
3. A bill in regard to which the President of India notified his/her intention to summon the Houses to a joint sitting, lapses on the dissolution of the Lok Sabha.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a) 1 only

b) 1 and 2

c) 2 and 3

d) 3 only

Ans: b

Q. With reference to the Parliament of India, consider the following statements: (2024)

1. Prorogation of a House by the President of India does not require the advice of the Council of Ministers
2. Prorogation of a House is generally done after the House is adjourned sine die but there is no bar to the President of India prorogating the House which is in session.
3. Dissolution of the Lok Sabha is done by the President of India who, save in exceptional circumstances, does so on the advice of the Council of Ministers.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

a) 1 only

b) 1 and 2

c) 2 and 3

d) 3 only

Ans: c

Oil Spill and its Implications

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Source: DD

Why in News?

A massive **"oil slick"** covering an estimated 160 square kilometres has reached the coastline of the United Arab Emirates (UAE), forcing the closure of **several beaches in Sharjah and Umm al-Quwain.** The spill poses a severe infrastructural threat to the region's desalination plants, which supply the majority of the nation's drinking water.

What is an Oil Spill?

- **About:** An oil spill is the uncontrolled release of **liquid petroleum hydrocarbons** into the environment, especially marine areas, due to human activities like tanker accidents, offshore drilling blowouts, or pipeline leaks.
- **Formation of Oil Slicks:** Most petroleum oils are less dense than water and spread rapidly across the surface, forming a thin layer called an oil slick.
  - As the oil spreads, it becomes progressively thinner and may form a rainbow-coloured sheen. However, heavier oils or those mixed with sediment can sink and contaminate the seabed.
- **Implications:**
  - **Infrastructure Damage:** Polluted seawater drawn into desalination facilities can clog delicate piping, **foul filtration membranes, and severely damage pumping infrastructure.**
  - **Water Security:** To prevent toxic hydrocarbons from entering the drinking water supply, plants **must shut down their intakes when an oil slick approaches.**
    - Prolonged shutdowns threaten the freshwater security of coastal cities.
  - **Marine Ecosystem Damage:** Oil films can reduce light penetration and hinder gas exchange, while microbial degradation of hydrocarbons can consume dissolved oxygen, contributing to hypoxia.
    - Oil can also physically smother coastal and benthic organisms, including corals.
  - **Biodiversity Loss:** Toxic compounds in crude oil compromise the reproductive success of seabirds, sea turtles, and fish.
  - **Economy:** The physical presence of oil on the shorelines disrupts coastal tourism, halts local fishing activities, and demands highly expensive, resource-intensive physical cleanup operations.
- **Regulation of Oil Spills in India:**
  - **Indian Coast Guard (ICG):** The **ICG** is the designated Central Coordinating Authority for combating

marine oil spills in Indian maritime zones.

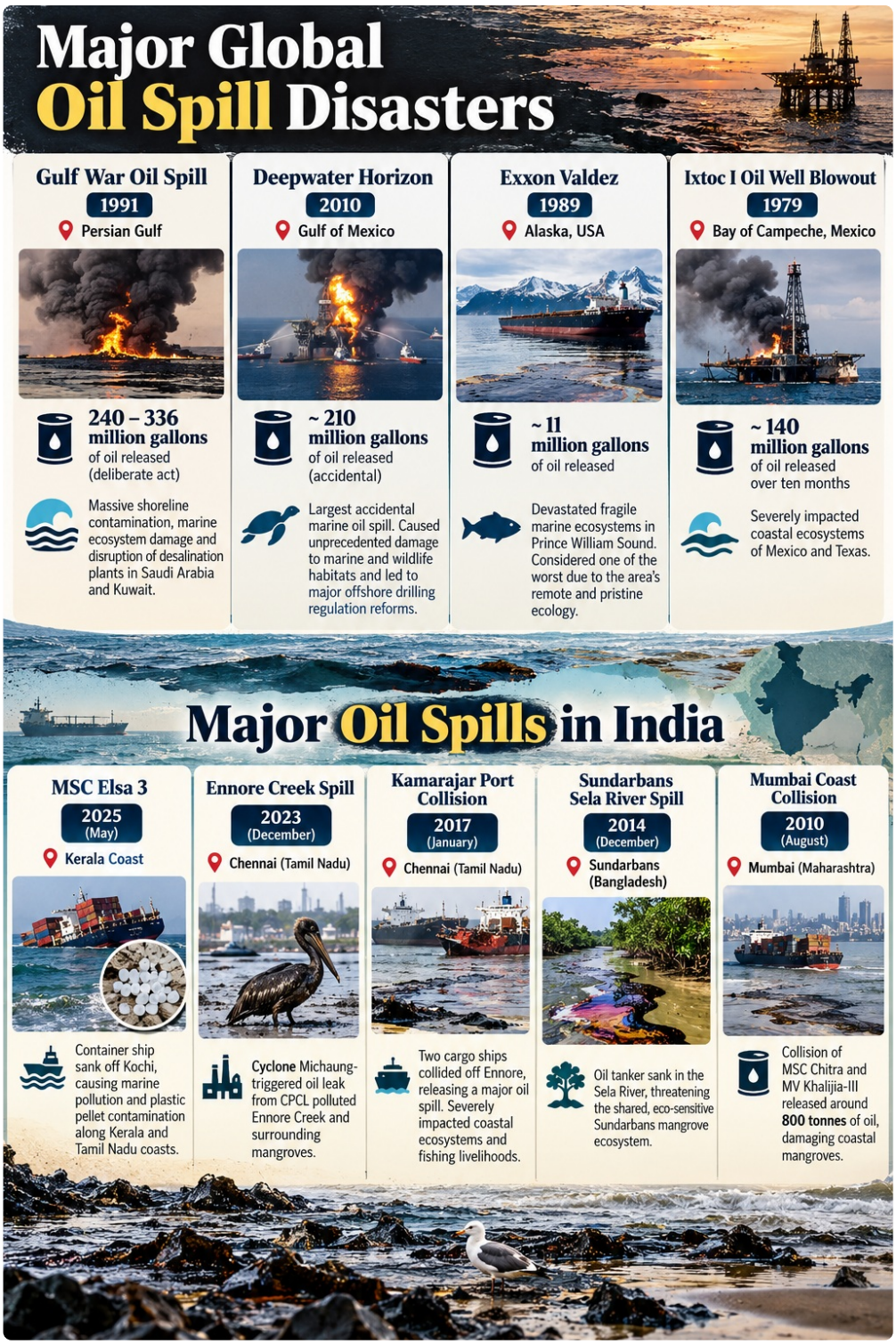
- **National Oil Spill Disaster Contingency Plan (NOS-DCP):** Promulgated in 1996, it forms the apex framework outlining standard operating procedures, resource pooling, and the national strategy for responding to Tier-I, II, and III oil spills.
- **Merchant Shipping Act, 1958:** Serves as the primary maritime legislation. Incorporates provisions of the **International Convention for the Prevention of Pollution from Ships (MARPOL)** Convention to regulate ship-borne pollution, including oil discharges.

- **International Frameworks:**
  - **MARPOL 73/78: MARPOL** is the main global framework administered by the **International Maritime Organization (IMO)** to prevent marine pollution from operational and accidental ship causes.
    - **India ratified Annex I of MARPOL in 1986,** which strictly regulates the prevention of pollution by oil from both operational measures (like bilge pumping) and accidental discharges.
  - **OPRC Convention, 1990:** India has ratified the **International Convention on Oil Pollution Preparedness, Response and Co-operation (OPRC)** administered by the IMO to facilitate international cooperation in combating major incidents or threats of marine pollution.
  - **Civil Liability Convention (CLC):** An IMO framework ensuring compensation for oil pollution damage. **India has ratified its 1992 Protocol** , which imposes strict liability on shipowners and mandates compulsory insurance for oil tankers carrying bulk cargo.
  - **Bunker Oil Convention (2001):** An IMO framework ensuring prompt compensation for damage caused by **bunker oil spills** (fuel or lubricating oil used for a ship's operation and propulsion).
    - Unlike the CLC, it applies to *all* seagoing vessels, not just oil tankers. **India ratified it in 2015.**

Measures to Clean Oil Spills

- **Mechanical Containment & Recovery:**
  - **Booms:** Floating physical barriers placed around the oil slick to contain the spill, prevent it from spreading, and protect sensitive coastal ecosystems.
  - **Skimmers:** Specialized vessels or mechanical devices used t **o physically skim, scoop, and separate the floating crude oil** from the water's surface.
  - **Sorbents:** Highly absorbent or adsorbent materials (such as **polyurethane foam, peat moss, or straw)** deployed to soak up residual oil from the water surface, acting like a sponge to recover petroleum hydrocarbons.
- **Chemical Dispersants:** Surfactant chemicals sprayed via aircraft or boats that reduce water surface tension, breaking the oil slick into micro-droplets. This allows the oil to mix with the water column and be degraded more easily by natural marine microbes.
  - **Corexit 9500** and **Corexit 9527** are widely utilized commercial chemical dispersants in major marine oil spill responses.
- **Bioremediation:** The deployment of **specific microbial agents** to organically consume and break down petroleum hydrocarbons.
  - These naturally occurring or genetically engineered bacteria utilize hydrocarbons as a carbon and energy source, degrading them into harmless byproducts.
  - Species of ***Pseudomonas*** **possess** a natural biological capability to degrade complex hydrocarbons found in crude oil and petroleum products.
    - Through genetic manipulation, targeted strains o **f *Pseudomonas* have been engineered to efficiently metabolize a vast spectrum of marine oil spills.**

- **Oilzapper:** Developed by The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI), Oilzapper is a bioremediation formulation containing a consortium of five naturally occurring bacterial strains capable of degrading petroleum hydrocarbons in contaminated environments.
- **In-Situ Burning:** The controlled ignition of the floating oil slick on the water surface. While it can efficiently eliminate massive volumes of oil quickly, it releases toxic air pollutants, black carbon, and greenhouse gases into the atmosphere.



Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is an oil spill?
An oil spill is the uncontrolled release of petroleum hydrocarbons into the environment, particularly marine ecosystems, due to tanker accidents, offshore drilling or pipeline leaks.

2. Which authority coordinates oil spill response in India's maritime zones?
The Indian Coast Guard (ICG) is the designated Central Coordinating Authority for combating marine oil spills in Indian maritime zones.

3. What is the National Oil Spill Disaster Contingency Plan (NOS-DCP)?
Promulgated in 1996, it provides the national framework for oil spill preparedness and response, including resource pooling and procedures for Tier I, II and III spills.

4. What are the major international conventions governing marine oil pollution?
Key conventions include MARPOL 73/78, OPRC 1990, Civil Liability Convention (CLC) and Bunker Oil Convention, 2001.

5. What is Oilzapper and how does it help in oil spill management?
Developed by TERI, Oilzapper is a bioremediation formulation containing five bacterial strains that help degrade petroleum hydrocarbons in contaminated environments.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/oaz77508WzQ**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. Which bacterial strain, developed from natural isolates by genetic manipulations, can be used for treating oil spills? (2010)

(a) Agrobacterium

(b) Clostridium

(C) Nitrosomonas

(d) Pseudomonas

Ans: D

India Offers Counter-Terrorism Expertise to ASEAN and ADMM-Plus Partners

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Source: TH

The Defence Minister addressing the **13 th ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting-Plus (ADMM-Plus)** in **Cebu, Philippines,** offered to share India's counter-terrorism expertise with ASEAN members and their dialogue partners.

- **Counter-Terrorism Cooperation** : India proposed strengthening collective capabilities through **joint military exercises, capacity-building programmes and intelligence sharing,** drawing on its operational experience in **counter-terrorism.**
  - The Defence Minister cited **Operation Sindoor as an example of India's approach to cross-border and state-sponsored terrorism.**
- **Indo-Pacific Vision** : India called for a **secure, stable and resilient Indo-Pacific** based on cooperation and respect for international law.
- **Maritime Security:** India highlighted **2026 as the ASEAN–India Year of Maritime Cooperation** and the conduct of the second ASEAN–India Maritime Exercise.
  - India emphasised freedom of navigation and overflight, security of maritime trade routes and adherence to the **United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS)** .
  - The Indian Navy's continuous operational presence in the **Gulf of Aden since 2008** was cited as evidence of India's commitment to protecting commercial shipping.
- **Defence Youth Bridge:** India proposed a dedicated defence **'Youth Bridge' to strengthen India–ASEAN** people-to-people connections, promote digital innovation and facilitate capacity building among young people.

ADMM Plus

- **About:** It is a platform comprising **ASEAN member states and eight dialogue partners** to strengthen regional security and defence cooperation.
- **Dialogue Partners:** Australia, China, India, Japan, New Zealand, Republic of Korea, Russia and the United States.
- **Establishment:** The inaugural **ADMM-Plus was held in Hanoi, Vietnam,** in October 2010, and the forum has **met annually since 2017.**
- **Areas of Cooperation** : Seven priority areas — **maritime security, counter-terrorism, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief, peacekeeping operations, military medicine** , **humanitarian mine action and cybersecurity** — are supported by Experts' Working Groups.
- **India's Role:** India and Malaysia co-chair the **ADMM-Plus Experts' Working Group on Counter-Terrorism for 2024–2027.**

Read more: **10th ASEAN Defence Ministers’ Meeting-Plus**

New Dwarf Planet Candidate 2026 ED138 Discovered Beyond Pluto

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Source: TH

Astronomers using the **Vera C. Rubin Observatory in Chile have discovered 2026 ED138,** an icy celestial object orbiting beyond Pluto that could potentially qualify as a dwarf planet, subject to further observations. The observatory is a joint initiative of the US National Science Foundation (NSF) and the US Department of Energy (DOE).

- **Location:** A distant **trans-Neptunian object (TNO) orbiting approximately 46 astronomical units (AU)** from the Sun, compared with Pluto's average orbital distance of about 40 AU.
  - One astronomical unit (AU) represents the average distance between Earth and the Sun, approximately 149.6 million km.
- **Estimated Size:** Its diameter is **estimated at 600–1,500 km** , potentially making it one of the larger dwarf planets in the outer Solar System. The estimate depends on its albedo (surface reflectivity), as a smaller, highly reflective object can appear as bright as a larger, darker object.
- **Orbital Characteristics:** Its orbit is **inclined approximately 25° to the Solar System's orbital plane** , classifying it as a hot-classical trans-Neptunian object.
- **Significance** : The discovery highlights the capabilities of the **Vera C. Rubin Observatory's Legacy Survey of Space and Time (LSST)** , designed to repeatedly survey the southern sky over approximately 10 years.
  - Such observations can **reveal previously undetected celestial objects and improve understanding of the formation and evolution of the outer Solar System** , including planetary migration.

Dwarf Planets

- **Definition:** According to the **International Astronomical Union (IAU)** , a dwarf planet is a celestial body that
  - Orbits the Sun.
  - Has sufficient mass for its gravity to maintain a nearly spherical shape.
  - Has not cleared its orbital neighbourhood of other objects.
  - Is not a satellite.
- **Recognised Dwarf Planets: The** IAU recognises five dwarf planets — **Ceres, Pluto, Haumea, Makemake and Eris.**
  - Ceres lies in the asteroid belt between Mars and Jupiter, while the other four orbit beyond Neptune.
- **Pluto's Reclassification:** The IAU reclassified Pluto as a dwarf planet in 2006 because it had not cleared its orbital neighbourhood.

Read More: New Dwarf Planet and Planet Nine

INS Sahyadri Participates in India-South Korea Naval Exercise

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Source: PIB

The **Indian Navy's INS Sahyadri** , an indigenously designed and built guided-missile stealth frigate, arrived at **Busan Naval Harbour, Republic of Korea (South Korea)** to participate in the **India-Republic of Korea Navy (IN-RoKN) Bilateral Exercise.**

- **Participating Warships:** The exercise involves INS Sahyadri of the Indian Navy and ROKS Munmu the Great, a guided-missile destroyer of the Republic of Korea Navy (RoKN).
- **Objective:** Enhance bilateral maritime cooperation, operational readiness and professional engagement between the two navies.
- **Harbour Phase:** Includes p **rofessional interactions, cross-deck visits, cross-training activities and sporting events** to facilitate the exchange of operational experiences and best practices.
- **Sea Phase:** Involves **coordinated maritime activities** to strengthen operational coordination, naval interoperability and mutual understanding.
- **Significance:** Reinforces the India-South Korea strategic partnership and their shared commitment to peace, stability and maritime security in the Indo-Pacific.

INS Sahyadri

- **About:** A **Shivalik-class (Project 17) guided-missile stealth frigate** and the third and final warship of the class, following INS Shivalik and INS Satpura.
- **Indigenous Construction:** Designed by the Indian Navy's Warship Design Bureau and built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDL), Mumbai.
- **Commissioning:** Commissioned into the Indian Navy in 2012, it is equipped for multi-role naval operations, including anti-surface warfare, anti-submarine warfare and air defence.

Read More: **INS Sahyadri Participates in JAIMEX-25**

India Becomes World’s 3rd-Largest Automobile Industry

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Source: TH

India’s automobile industry , valued at approximately **₹22 lakh crore, has overtaken Japan,** making India the world's third-largest automobile market by new-vehicle sales, after China and the United States **.**

- **Industry Growth** : India's automobile industry has expanded from approximately **₹14 lakh crore to ₹22 lakh crore** , reflecting growth in domestic vehicle manufacturing and the automotive market.
  - According to the **International Organisation of Motor Vehicle Manufacturers (OICA),** India recorded approximately 55.18 lakh new motor vehicle sales in 2025, ahead of Japan's 45.66 lakh.
- **Economic Contribution:** The automobile sector contributes approximately **₹4.5 lakh crore in revenue to Central and State Governments** and supports around **4.5 crore** jobs, strengthening industrial production and ancillary industries.
- **Automobile Exports:** India's vehicle exports increased by **approximately 24% to over 67 lakh units in FY 2025–26,** driven by demand for passenger vehicles, two-wheelers and commercial vehicles **.**
- **Infrastructure Development:** Improved highways and expressways have reduced India’s logistics costs by **6%** and travel time, while supporting economic activity along transport corridors.
- **Green Hydrogen:** Indian farmers are increasingly being considered **potential contributors to hydrogen** and other energy production, which could help reduce dependence on imported energy resources.
- **Energy Exports:** Expansion of domestic hydrogen production could create opportunities for India to **emerge as an energy-exporting country.**
- **Economic Linkages:** Automobile manufacturing supports **employment, industrial production, ancillary industries and technological development.**
- **Significance:** The growth of India's automobile industry boosts **domestic manufacturing, employment, exports and ancillary industries,** while strengthening industrial competitiveness and India's position in the global automotive market **.**

Read more: India’s Automobile Sector